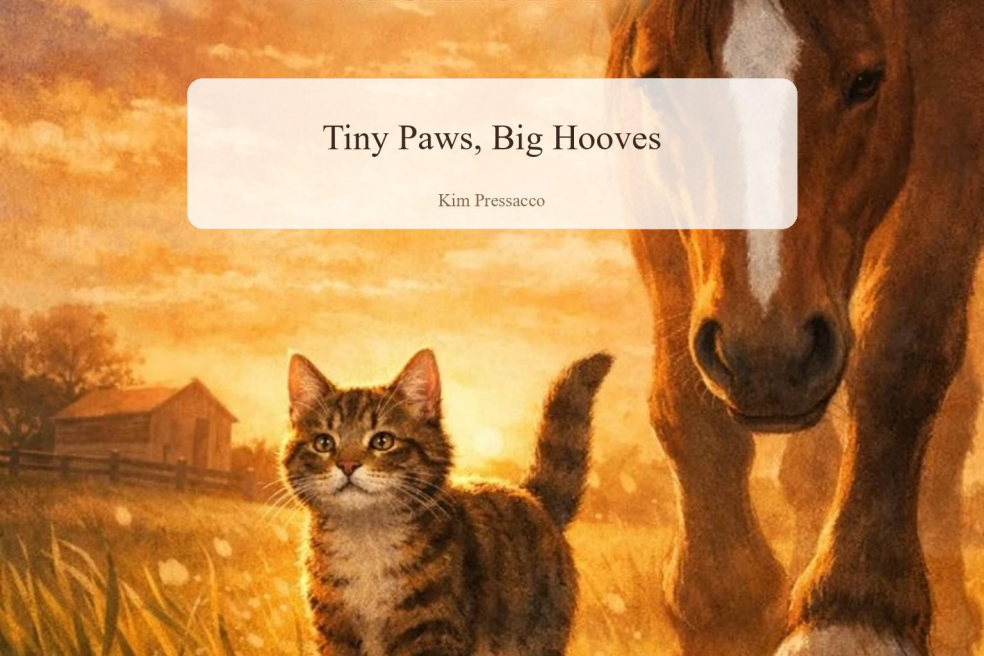


Tiny Paws, Big Hooves

Kim Pressacco



Tiny Paws, Big Hooves
by Kim Pressacco

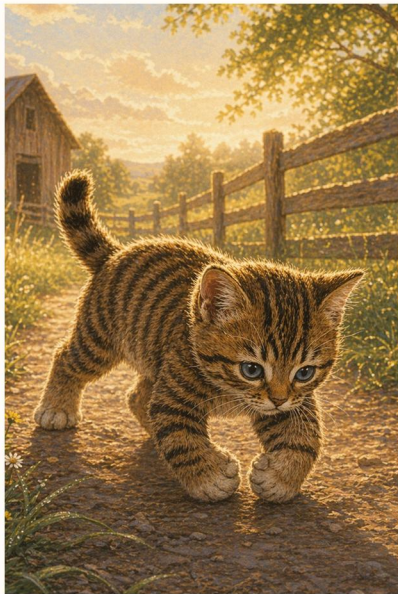
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Harvey had wobbly
beginnings.

His back legs bent a little
sideways, and when he
walked, he waddled forward
like a tiny gorilla.

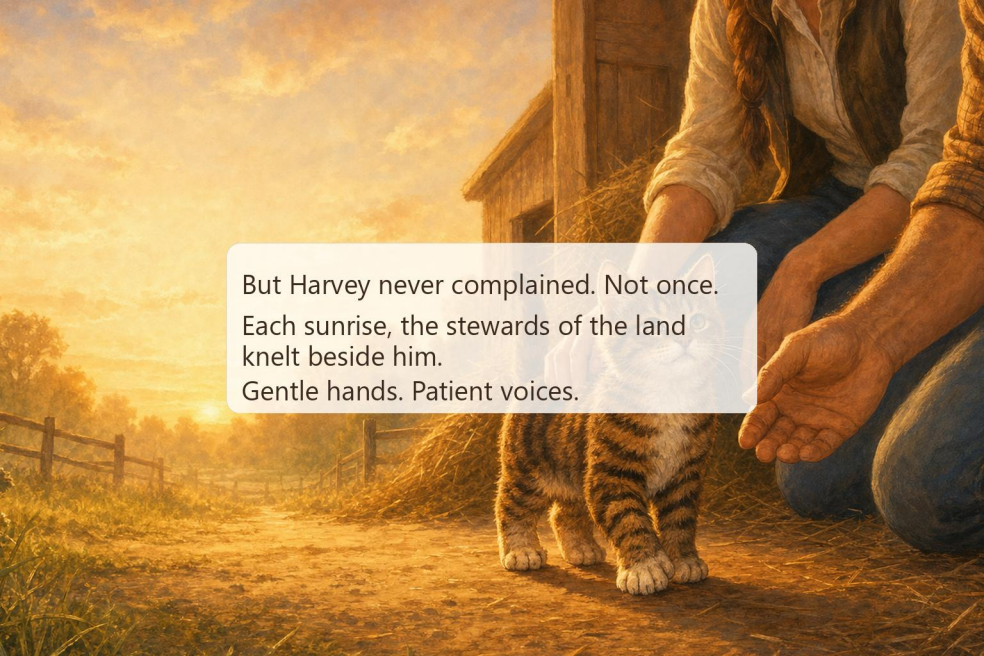
Plop. Step. Plop.



On each paw, Harvey had six toes. Six small toes that spread wide when he stepped.

Sometimes he tripped over them.



A person with a long braid, wearing a light shirt and dark vest, is kneeling on a dirt path. They are reaching out with their hands towards a small, striped tabby kitten. The kitten is standing on the path, looking up at the person's hands. In the background, there is a wooden barn, a fence, and a bright sunrise over a field with trees. The scene is bathed in warm, golden light.

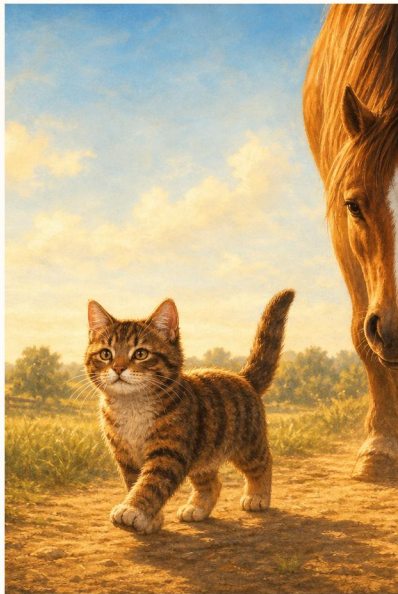
But Harvey never complained. Not once.
Each sunrise, the stewards of the land
knelt beside him.
Gentle hands. Patient voices.



Kim stretched one little leg. Then the other. "Strong toes," she whispered. "Strong heart. " Harvey purred the whole time. He didn't fuss.

He didn't frown. He simply tried again. Wobble. Stretch. Try again. And slowly... The wobble grew smaller. Days passed.





The tiny gorilla walk became a careful kitten walk. The careful kitten walk became a steady little stride.

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One morning, Harvey trotted across the barn floor. No plop. No tumble. Just paws on wood. Light and sure. The stewards smiled.

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“You’re growing strong,” they said. Harvey hadn’t noticed the change. He had just kept trying. The farm was full of big things.

No image yet

Big sheep with woolly coats. Big dogs with booming barks.
And the biggest of all— Marlin.

No image yet

Marlin was strong and handsome, with a shiny dark brown coat that sparkled in the sunlight.

No image yet

Down the center of his face ran a bold white blaze— like a streak of moonlight painted just for him.

No image yet

His hooves pressed steadily into the earth. Harvey looked up. And up. And up. “I am very small,” he whispered.

No image yet

The animals didn't mean to be unkind. Bella barked as she ran past him. The sheep shuffled in big woolly clusters.

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One lamb blinked at Harvey and said, “You’re the size of my ear! ” Harvey tried to laugh. But sometimes, Being tiny felt heavy.

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One warm afternoon, the barn was quiet. Sunlight slipped through the wooden boards, painting golden stripes across the floor.

No image yet

The round hay bales stood tall and heavy, stacked in careful rows. A curious little lamb wandered inside.

No image yet

She squeezed between two hay bales— just a little too far. The space shifted. “Baa baa! ” she cried. The opening was narrow.

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Too tight for dogs. Too tall and close for hooves. Marlin stepped forward, His great body fills the doorway.

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But the bales left no room. Bella barked. Dust swirled in the light. Everything felt big. Everything felt loud. Harvey stood very still.

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He looked at the towering stacks. He looked at the small gap.
He looked at his paws. Six toes on each one. Small. Wide.

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Steady. His heart beat fast. Not afraid. Focused. Harvey stepped toward the bales. He placed one paw carefully on the rough hay twine.

No image yet

His six toes spread wide, gripping and holding. He climbed. Careful. Balanced. Sure. He remembered his early steps. The wobble. The practice. Tiny squeeze.

No image yet

Tiny turn. “Baa baa,” the lamb cried softly. “I’m here,” Harvey whispered. “Follow my voice. ” Slowly, the lamb backed out.

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Harvey guided her one small step at a time. And then— They were free. The lamb bounded toward the flock.

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The barn grew quiet again. Marlin lowered his great head. His breath warmed Harvey's fur. "You were exactly the right size," Marlin said.

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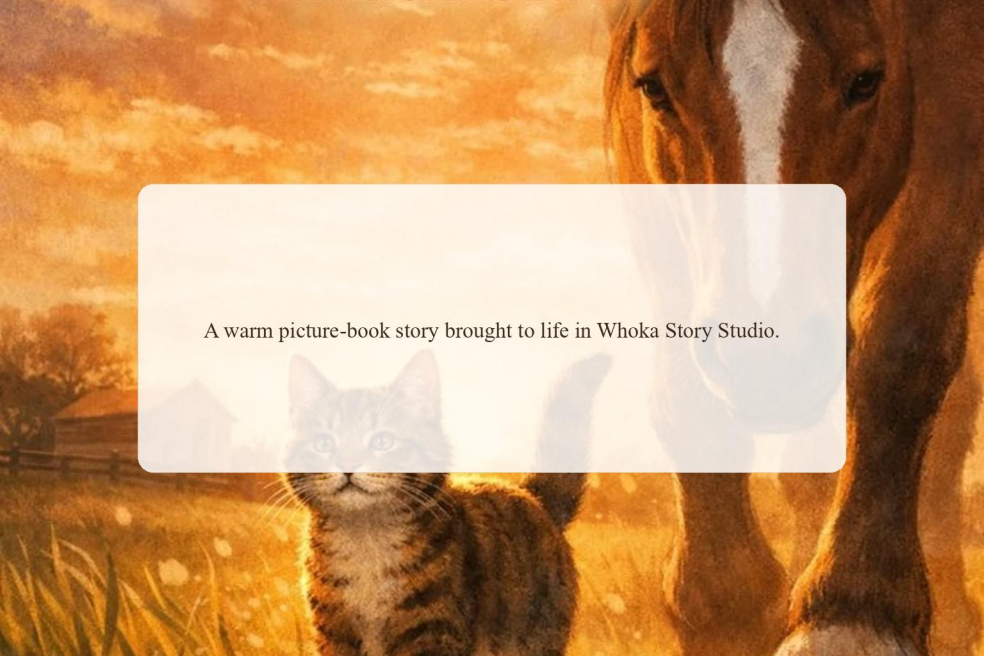
Harvey blinked. “I was? ” Marlin’s white blaze glowed in the dusty light. “Too big, and you could not fit.

No image yet

Too small in spirit, and you would not have tried. ” Harvey looked down at his paws. They were straight now. Strong. Sure.

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“That was my practice phase,” he said softly. Marlin nodded. “Every steady stride has a beginning. ” The next morning, the sun rose gently over the pasture. Harvey stretched— not because he had to... but because he liked to. He stepped forward. No wobble. No plop. Just quiet confidence. He padded across the field. Marlin walked beside him. Dark coat shining. White blaze bright as moonlight. Big hooves. Tiny paws. Side by side. Harvey did not look up anymore. He did not look down. He simply walked. And for the first time, He felt perfectly sized.

A warm, golden-hour illustration of a horse and a cat in a field. The horse, with a white blaze on its face, is on the right, looking down. The cat, a tabby, is in the foreground, looking up. The background shows a field with a barn and trees under a sunset sky.

A warm picture-book story brought to life in Whoka Story Studio.